

CHAPTER EIGHT

Rio de Janeiro

CHAPTER EIGHT

PART ONE

Both Sedoff and I were assigned to Rio de Janeiro station effective at the end of the fiscal year, June 30, 1965. I commenced the study of the Portuguese language full time upon our return from the TDY trip to Rio. My study of the Portuguese language was by a private tutor who was somewhat of a goof-off so I didn't get as much out of the training as I had hoped. Most of our activities in the spring and summer of 1965 consisted in getting ready to go to Rio de Janeiro. We debated whether or not to sell the beautiful house that we had built in Cobbdale but decided to do so for a couple of reasons: firstly, we would have had to rent it during our absence and that would have involved getting a large family in it, since it was a six bedroom house; secondly, we didn't like the environment that Gail was getting into with certain of her friends in that neighborhood and preferred not to move back in that area if we could possibly avoid it.

Marion's mother, Rhoda Jones, came to visit us in April, 1965 but spent quite a bit of her visit in the hospital due to illness. We still held our stake conferences in the city of Washington, although by this time our stake had been divided making two stakes, Washington and Potomac. In those days we had a two session conference, going in the morning from 10:00 A.M. to 12 o'clock then having lunch, either a box lunch or going to the Hot Shoppes, and then returning for the afternoon sessions. As was normal the kids didn't particularly like going to conference but they did like going out for lunch in between times so it amounted to a trade off. Our son, Ronald, received his Duty to God award before we left for Rio, an achievement which called for a lot of devotion to his priesthood duties.

Just prior to leaving McLean we "sold" our old station wagon the "pink elephant" to Julian Lowe for \$1.00. We figured that the ward could use something to haul things back and forth during the construction of the new chapel. This feeling was a real prophecy because, upon our return, we found out that it had indeed performed a yoeman's job doing all sorts of tasks in connection with the construction of the building.

Our travel to Brazil was originally scheduled by ocean liner, the Moore-McCormack Lines again, to sail on June 25th. However, this was thwarted by a strike of the maritime workers so we had to delay to see if this strike would be settled. Having sold our house we stayed temporarily with the O'Bryants, a period of time which stretched out to be about a week. The failure to travel by

sea caused us a number of problems, not the least of which was what we were going to do with our dog, Frisky. We had already made arrangements to have a kennel on the ship but finally determined that we would leave the dog with the O'Bryants while we were in Rio, which turned out for the best because Frisky had been injured earlier and had a shoulder problem which resulted in eventually having to be put asleep, so there wasn't a problem as to who got the dog when we returned from overseas.

We went to New York on June 29 and took in the New York World's Fair while staying in some temporary quarters which the State Department had for its diplomats who got caught in situations like this. It finally got to the point where it was obvious that the strike was not going to be settled so we had to go down to the Port of New York, rifle through our sea trunks and pull out what we could get into luggage to fly down to Rio instead. Finally departed, all six of us, in cramped seats in the aircraft since about everybody who was trying to get to Rio was on the plane with us. We arrived in Rio on the 4th of July, 1965 with a lot of aches and pains and Marion with very swollen feet, not a very auspicious beginning for our tour of duty.

As was always the case when we went overseas we had to take some temporary quarters in a hotel until we were able to find a house for us to rent. Initially we stayed at the Hotel California on the Copacabana beach, the same hotel where Walt Sedoff and I stayed during our TDY there the previous year. Eventually we found us a house to rent not too far from where the Rio de Janeiro branch of the church met. It was on a street called Lopez Quintas, which was more or less at the foot of Corcovado mountain. This is the mountain which has a towering statue of Christ on it which can be seen from many miles away, it being one of the principal landmarks of Rio de Janeiro. Unfortunately, this street was a cobblestone one and was just below an abandoned quarry which collected thousands of gallons of rainfall before spilling over into the street and wiping it out, an event which took place about five or six times during our stay in Rio.

We belonged to the Jardim Botânico (Botanical Gardens) Branch of the Rio de Janeiro Mission. It was just a few blocks down the street from where we lived so was within easy walking distance. Another American family, the Henry Bradfords, lived close to the branch as well. They were assigned to A.I.D. (Agency for International Development) and had quite a few children some of who were near the ages of ours. Shortly after arriving I was called to serve in the branch presidency, along with Val Carter, and a local Brazilian professor as the branch president. I think his name was Aristogiden Carvalho.

We had quite a few Brazilian members but not many were truly active. As one knows the Church demands a lot of time on Sunday, the day that most working Brazilians went to the beaches. It was also difficult to get them there on weekdays as the Brazilian school system in Rio ran two sessions per day, the second one not getting over until about 6:00 in the evening. Besides this the members had to rely on public transportation since very few had such a thing as an automobile. Marion was President of the Primary as well as being the organist for the Jr. Sunday School.

Our first Christmas in Rio we had the Americans from our church over for a Christmas Eve party. It was after we went to bed that we found out how Brazilians celebrated Christmas Eve. Actually it was about 1:30 A.M. when we saw a man coming up the street with a huge bongo drum, beating it for all he was worth, and around him shouting and singing, were a group of characters dressed up in clown costumes and one in a Santa suit and dancing and prancing.

On New Year's Eve, the beaches of Rio de Janeiro are filled with Macumba ceremonies, the Macumbas being a spiritualist import from Africa. They don't mind outsiders watching as long as they don't get too close. It was interesting but somewhat eerie. There was a young girl all dressed in white, whom we supposed was a new inductee into the cult. The other members would all stand around in a circle swaying and chanting and clapping their hands. The girl seemed to be in a trance. They sat her down and took a white chicken which they killed and sprinkled her with its blood. After several more ceremonial things, the young girl and several other women took flowers in their arms and walked out into the surf of the ocean and it looked as if they would just keep on going out into the ocean. Evidences of Macumba rites could be found all over Rio, on street corner, in niches in the mountains alongside the roads and they consisted basically of a bottle, a candle and a cigar.

PART TWO

Professionally this tour of duty was quite unsatisfactory. There was a so-called agent-in-place attached to the Soviet Commercial Section. He was the one Walt Sedoff and I contacted when we were in Rio the previous year. In December 1965 and January 1966 most of my operational effort was directed toward trying to recruit a suspected GRU (Soviet Military Intelligence) officer who was carrying on an affair with a Brazilian girl. We did have a recruiter talk to him but he was pulled out of his apartment, into the Soviet Embassy and shipped back to the Soviet Union before we could finalize anything. The balance of our operational effort was to recruit as sources third national individuals who were in social or business contact with a Soviet official and who could be utilized as an

access agent to establish a relationship with the Soviet which might eventually result in a recruitment.

We also maintained direct social contact with some of the KGB officers so as to provide an avenue for defection if and when any of them became disaffected. Marion and I spent quite a few evenings out with a Soviet named Borsov and his wife. Nothing ever came of it but this policy worked in some areas of the world to provide access for the Soviets to American intelligence.

We never got a chance to travel much while in Brazil except to visit the modernistic capital, Brasilia, and also Sao Paulo, the largest city of Brasil and it's industrial and business center. Marion did get on a trip with a club she belonged to during which time she proceeded to break her ankle which caused her a lot of problems because she walked on the cast before it was set properly and it had to be redone when she returned to Rio de Janeiro. This was the first part of June 1966. She visited Sao Paulo, Campinas and a small town in the interior called Matao, which held a big religious procession on Corpus Christi Day (June 9). for this procession the townspeople decorated the streets with flower petals and other colored substances depicting Christian themes and symbols that the Catholics use.

As I have mentioned there were a lot of floods while we were there and our street kept getting wiped out requiring us to spend a lot of time walking up and down the hill leading to our house. On one occasion Marion and I were having dinner with an American couple whom I was developing for access purposes when it started to rain profusely. We cut our meeting short and while returning via the Jockey Club area the operational car I was driving got swamped in several feet of water. A group of the "favelados" (residents of the slum areas known as favelas) offered to push us to higher ground for a price. However, instead of doing so they pushed us into deeper water and then stuck a gun in our face, robbing us of our money and some of Marion's jewelry. We had to wade up to our waists until we cleared the Jockey Club area and reached higher ground. A police contact that I used to run surveillance teams said that we were both very lucky to have escaped alive since the holdup people didn't like to leave witnesses.

I did have a good operational relationship with a Brazilian official (number three man in their foreign office) who provided me with a lot of useful information on the activities and plans of the Soviets in Brazil. His office was responsible for direct contact with them and all requests for commercial activity had to come through him. It helped me keep track of many of the assignments of the KGB and GRU officers who were under cover in both the Soviet Embassy and in their Commercial Section.

Our social activity in the diplomatic circle was much more limited than it had been in Montevideo. We were invited to some of the social functions involving the Embassy staff but not all of them as we had in Montevideo. However, we were invited to the reception when former Vice-President Richard Nixon paid an official visit. We had met him previously when we were in Montevideo. One of the persons in the Political Section who was very useful to us was a Foreign Service officer named Frank Carlucci, who held some dinner parties to which he invited third national diplomats whom we could meet and who had access to Soviets. Frank Carlucci had a fabulous career after leaving Rio, including being deputy director of C.I.A and as of 1988 the Secretary of Defense.

In Montevideo we had had visits from several General Authorities, i.e. Elders Kimball and Lee, so we were quite pleased when Elder Richard L. Evans, a member of the Quorum of Twelve, came to Rio although it was not in his capacity as a church official. At that time (1966) he was serving as the President of Rotary International and he was in Brazil for a convention of Rotarians, who held a large luncheon for him. Apparently, the Embassy had done its homework and found that I was a member of the staff who belonged to the L.D.S. church so Marion and I were invited to the luncheon and I was asked to sit on the dais with Elder Evans. As you will recall Elder Evans was known as the "voice of the Mormon Tabernacle Choir" for many years and was known for signing off with the expression "may peace be with you this day and always."

One of the men I worked with (a Lithuanian named Bruno) brought us a young parrot (papagaio verdadeiro) whom we named Fred and was a lot of enjoyment to us. He learned to speak quite well, however, rather than learn the phrases which we tried to teach him, he picked up the phrases which we commonly used around the house. He would say, "Gail, telephone" or "Hilton, where are you?" We usually kept him on his perch on the front balcony where the ping-pong table was located. The children and the missionaries used to play a lot of ping-pong there and Fred would imitate the sound of the clock-clock of the ball as it went back and forth over the net. He also mimicked Marion as she was taking her warm-ups for the singing lessons she was taking at the time. One Thanksgiving day we forgot to put him on the front balcony perch and left him instead on the back balcony. That night he was killed by an opossum (we think.) It was quite a loss to us.

In May 1966 our whole family was sick with intestinal amoebae and it took some potent medicine to get rid of them over a period of about two months. We used boiled and filtered water but got the amoebae in spite of all these precautions. It turned out that our maid didn't understand

the necessity of boiling the water from which she made the ice cubes. The Brazilians being accustomed to the "bugs" couldn't quite understand why the American members insisted on bringing the water for the sacrament table either.

The last part of October 1966, Helen Jeanne Jepps, Marion's sister came to visit us and Marion had a good time going places and shopping with her. We also had a visit the following April, from my brother, Martin and his wife Betty.

All of our children attended school while in Rio. Hilton was in a Brazilian kindergarden and the others attended the Escola Americana, from which Ron graduated in 1966. He went to Utah to attend BYU in the fall of 1966, the first time that any of our children had been away from us for an extended period of time. I think that he enjoyed being on his own although he spent most of the money he was sent for clothes to buy camera equipment. After the completion of his first year, he returned to Rio and was able to work at our C.I.A. office as a part-time cameraman for a couple of months.

During the cooler weather in Rio de Janeiro we went on little sight-seeing excursions (Hilton called them adventures). We had been to the statue of Christ on top of Mt. Corcovado and to Pao de Azucar (Sugar Loaf) and the regular tourists places. We started to go to places a little different, we climbed on some rocks way above the ocean on the way to Vista Chinesa which is practically in a jungle overlooking the city. One of the things that made Rio depressing was all the filth and poverty. Every place you went it was dirty and people were living in squalor. For example right across from the American Embassy in downtown Rio was a small square with a fountain and people actually lived on the grass around the fountain and bathed and washed in it. There was poverty everywhere and nothing seemed to be done about it.

We finished our tour in early July just after Stu and Dottie Burton arrived so we only overlapped for a few days. On our way home we stopped in Panama for a little sightseeing then flew on to California for a visit with the folks there before renting a station wagon and driving to Utah. On our way to Utah we stopped to see some of the Utah Parks such as Bryce and Zion which the kids enjoyed very much. As usual we spent the majority of our home leave in Utah visiting the relatives there and giving the children a chance to renew acquaintanceships with their cousins on Marion's side of the family. Ron got a job working on construction in Provo so stayed there rather than returning to Virginia with us since it was so close to the time his second year at the Y was to start. We also knew that he would be getting his mission call in the Spring after he turned nineteen. Because of the situation in Vietnam, the

Church discouraged farewells for missionaries and as a result Ron never got to know the people in the McLean Ward very well prior to his departure, which was unfortunate and I felt guilty not having him back prior to his starting the school year.